

[Lesson 45](#): “The Family Is Ordained of God” (See L45 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us understand the eternal importance of the family and to inspire us to strengthen our families.

1. The family is central to God’s plan. (1st and 2nd paragraphs of “The Family: A Proclamation.”)

“ ‘[The Family: A Proclamation to the World](#)’ was presented by President Gordon B. Hinckley at the general Relief Society meeting in September 1995. Since that time, it has been reprinted in many languages for Church members and others throughout the world. It has also been presented to government leaders in many lands.” (*Lesson Manual*)

What is happening in our families, communities, and nation that suggests a need for this prophetic counsel?

†1. President Gordon B. Hinckley

Why is the family central to God’s plan for His children? (See [D&C 131:1–4](#); [1 Cor. 11:11](#))

How does knowing you are a member of God’s family affect your feelings about earthly families?

2. Sacred ordinances make it possible for families to be together eternally. (3rd paragraph)

- What does this paragraph teach about the purpose of mortal life?

How can our earthly experience help us in our eternal progression?

- How can we strengthen our commitment to keep our temple covenants?

In what ways can parents help children prepare to enter the temple?

- How should the promise of eternal life with our families affect the way we treat family members now?

3. The power to create mortal life is sacred. (4th and 5th paragraphs)

What has God commanded regarding the use of the power to create mortal life?

Why is obedience to this commandment important? †2. Elder Henry B. Eyring

†3. Elder Jeffrey R. Holland

What can parents do to help children understand the importance of moral cleanliness?

- Read *For the Strength of Youth: Sexual Purity*; *A Parent’s Guide: Chapter 6: Mature Intimacy: Courtship and Marriage*.

4. Parents have a sacred duty to care for each other and teach their children. (6th paragraph)

What can married couples do to strengthen their love for each other? †4. President Gordon B. Hinckley

How are children blessed when they have parents who love and care for each other?

- What are parents responsible to teach their children? (See [Mosiah 4:14–15](#); [D&C 68:25–28](#); [93:40](#).)

How have you benefited from your parents’ teachings?

What would you like your children to learn from you?

- What is the role of the Church in teaching children? †5. President Spencer W. Kimball

How can parents work together with the Church to teach their children?

5. Successful marriages and families are based on righteous principles. (7th paragraph)

How have the teachings of Christ brought happiness into your home?

Which of the principles mentioned have been especially important for your marriage and family?

What are the primary responsibilities of fathers?

What does it mean to “preside ... in love and righteousness”? (See [D&C 121:41–46](#).)

What are the primary responsibilities of mothers? †6. President Gordon B. Hinckley

How can fathers help nurture their children? Why should parents help each other as equal partners?

6. Strengthening families is everyone’s responsibility. (8th and 9th paragraphs)

What are some things you have done that strengthened and unified your family?

What can we do as individuals and families to promote stronger families in our own communities?

†7. President Gordon B. Hinckley Why must families be strong in order for nations to survive?

†8. Elder Robert D. Hales †9. President Spencer W. Kimball †10. President Joseph Fielding Smith

†11. President Spencer W. Kimball †12. The Importance of Families †13. Bruce Feiler—Family Stories

Next Week: L46: “Zion—The Pure in Heart”; See L46 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “Why do we have this proclamation on the family now? Because the family is under attack. All across the world families are falling apart. The place to begin to improve society is in the home. Children do, for the most part, what they are taught. We are trying to make the world better by making the family stronger” (“[Inspirational Thoughts](#),” *Ensign*, Aug. 1997, 5).

†2. **Elder Henry B. Eyring:** “Children are the inheritance of the Lord to us in this life and also in eternity. ...

“We can understand why our Heavenly Father commands us to reverence life and to cherish the powers that produce it as sacred. If we do not have those reverential feelings in this life, how could our Father give them to us in the eternities?” (“[The Family](#),” *Ensign*, Feb. 1998, 15).

†3. **Elder Jeffrey R. Holland:** “*The body is an essential part of the soul.* ... We declare that one who uses the God-given body of another without divine sanction abuses the very soul of that individual, abuses the central purpose and processes of life. ... In sexual transgression the soul is at stake—the body and the spirit” (“[Personal Purity](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1998, 76).

†4. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “When you are married, be fiercely loyal one to another. Selfishness is the great destroyer of happy family life. If you will make your first concern the comfort, the well-being, and the happiness of your companion, sublimating any personal concern to that loftier goal, you will be happy, and your marriage will go on throughout eternity” (“[Excerpts from Recent Addresses of President Gordon B. Hinckley](#),” *Ensign*, Dec. 1995, 67).

†5. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “It is the responsibility of the parents to teach their children. The Sunday School, the Primary, [Mutual,] and other organizations of the Church play a secondary role” (*The Teachings of Spencer W. Kimball*, ed. Edward L. Kimball [1982], 332).

†6. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “If there is to be a return to old and sacred values, it must begin in the home. It is here that truth is learned, that integrity is cultivated, that self-discipline is instilled, and that love is nurtured. ...

“Sisters, guard your children. ... Nothing is more precious to you as mothers, absolutely nothing. Your children are the most valuable thing you will have in time or all eternity...” (“[Walking in the Light of the Lord](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1998, 99).

†7. **President Gordon B. Hinckley** told a gathering of mayors and other public officials: “To you men and women of great influence, you who preside in the cities of the nation, to you I say that it will cost far less to reform our schools, to teach the virtues of good citizenship, than it will to go on building and maintaining costly jails and prisons. ... But there is another institution of even greater importance than the schools. It is the home. I believe that no nation can rise higher than the strength of its families” (“[News of the Church: U.S. Conference of Mayors](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1998, 109).

†8. **Elder Robert D. Hales:** “The plan of the Father is that family love and companionship will continue into the eternities. Being ... in a family carries a great responsibility of caring, loving, lifting, and strengthening each member of the family so that all can righteously endure to the end in mortality and dwell together throughout eternity. It is not enough just to save ourselves. It is equally important that parents, brothers, and sisters are saved in our families. If we return home alone to our Heavenly Father, we will be asked, ‘Where is the rest of the family?’” (“[The Eternal Family](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1996, 65).

†9. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “And to those who might decry marriage or postpone it or forbid it Paul spoke, condemning them. It is generally selfishness, cold and self-centered, which leads people to shun marriage responsibility. There are many who talk and write against marriage. Even some of our own delay marriage and argue against it... The Lord did not give sex to man for a plaything. Basically marriage presupposes a family. (“[Guidelines to Carry Forth the Work of God in Cleanliness](#),” *Ensign*, May 1974.)

Recommended reading:

1. Elder Jeffrey R. Holland, “[Personal Purity](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1998, 76.
2. “[Single-Parent Families](#),” at lds.org.
3. L. Whitney Clayton, “[Marriage: Watch and Learn](#),” *Ensign*, May 2013.
4. Elder W. Douglas Shumway, “[Marriage and Family: Our Sacred Responsibility](#),” *Ensign*, May 2004.
5. Elder Robert D. Hales, “[Strengthening Families: Our Sacred Duty](#),” *Ensign*, May 1999. This talk is filled with wonderful helps and tips.
6. “[The Family Is Ordained of God](#),” *Ensign*, Mar. 2003.

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†10. **President Joseph Fielding Smith:** “The thought of a nation without the family unit as its fundamental foundation; where all the citizens are, comparatively, strangers to each other, and where natural affection is not found; where no family ties bind the groups together, is one of horror. Such a condition could lead to but one end—anarchy and dissolution.” (*Doctrines of Salvation*, 2:66)

†11. **Elder Spencer W. Kimball:** Many “of the social restraints which in the past have helped to reinforce and to shore up the family are dissolving and disappearing. The time will come when only those who believe deeply and actively in the family will be able to preserve their families in the midst of the gathering evil around us.” (“[Families Can Be Eternal](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1980, 4.)

†12. **The Importance of Family:** “Children in their middle years treasure their families and feel they are special and irreplaceable. Families provide children with a sense of belonging and a unique identity. Families are, or should be, a source of emotional support and comfort, warmth and nurturing, protection and security. Family relationships provide children with a critical sense of being valued and with a vital network of historical linkages and social support. Within every healthy family there is a sense of reciprocity—a giving and taking of love and empathy by every family member.

“Families are much more than groups of individuals. They have their own goals and aspirations. They also are places where every child and adult should feel that he or she is special and be encouraged to pursue his or her own dreams; a place where everyone's individuality is permitted to flourish. Although every family has conflicts, all the family members should feel as though they can express themselves openly, share their feelings, and have their opinions listened to with understanding. In fact, conflicts and disagreements are a normal part of family life and are important insofar as they permit people to communicate their differences and ventilate their feelings.

“The family instructs children and gives guidance about personal values and social behavior. It instills discipline and helps them learn and internalize codes of conduct that will serve them for the rest of their lives. It helps them develop positive interpersonal relationships, and it provides an environment that encourages learning both in the home and at school. It gives children a sense of history and a secure base from which to grow and develop. Yet, as important as these functions are, they do not happen automatically. Every parent knows it takes hard work to keep the

family going as an effective, adaptive, and functional unit.” (“[The Importance of Family](#),” at [healthychildren.org](#) a site run by pediatricians accessed 12/7/12.)

Bruce Feiler—Family Stories: “I first heard this idea from Marshall Duke, a colorful psychologist at [Emory University](#). In the mid-1990s, Dr. Duke was asked to help explore myth and ritual in American families.

“ ‘There was a lot of research at the time into the dissipation of the family,’ he told me at his home in suburban Atlanta. ‘But we were more interested in what families could do to counteract those forces.’

“Around that time, Dr. Duke’s wife, Sara, a psychologist who works with children with learning disabilities, noticed something about her students.

“The ones who know a lot about their families tend to do better when they face challenges,” she said.

“Her husband was intrigued, and along with a colleague, Robyn Fivush, set out to test her hypothesis. They developed a measure called the ‘Do You Know?’ scale that asked children to answer 20 questions.

“Examples included: Do you know where your grandparents grew up? Do you know where your mom and dad went to high school? Do you know where your parents met? Do you know an illness or something really terrible that happened in your family? Do you know the story of your birth?

“Dr. Duke and Dr. Fivush asked those questions of four dozen families in the summer of 2001, and taped several of their dinner table conversations. They then compared the children’s results to a battery of psychological tests the children had taken, and reached an overwhelming conclusion. The more children knew about their family’s history, the stronger their sense of control over their lives, the higher their self-esteem and the more successfully they believed their families functioned. The ‘Do You Know?’ scale turned out to be the best single predictor of children’s emotional health and happiness.” (“[The Stories That Bind Us](#),” *The New York Times*, accessed Dec. 12, 2013.)

Recommended Media:

1. Video: “[The Family is Ordained of God](#)” (9:05)
2. Video: “[The Family is Central to the Creator’s Plan](#)” (3:21)
3. Video: [We Believe in Being Chaste](#) (1:17)
4. Video: [The Home is a Divine Institution](#) (1:50)

Further Recommended Reading:

1. Robert L. Simpson, “[A Lasting Marriage](#),” *Ensign*, May 1982.

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